COURSE :- LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS

TOPIC :- HOW DO DEMONSTRATIVE PRONOUNS CLEAR STRUCTURAL DEPENDENCY ?

Demonstrative Pronouns are words like ‘this, that, these, and those’ that point to specific people, animals, or things in place or time.
They stand alone instead of repeating a noun.
They usually sit right before a verb, not a noun. If followed by a noun, they act as adjectives.

This	Singular	Near / Recent	Links to the immediate, single clause or object.
That	Singular	Far / Distant	Links to a remote or prior concept.
These	Plural	Near / Recent	Groups multiple close items or statements.
Those	Plural	Far / Distant	Groups multiple distant or past elements.

Demonstrative pronouns clear structural dependencies through these key mechanisms:

- Eliminating Nested Relative Clauses/ Eliminating Clausal Embedding -

Sentences with multiple relative pronouns (which, who, that) create deep structural dependencies that strain working memory. Demonstratives break these hierarchies into coordinate structures.

Example : The strategy requires a budget update which triggers an audit that delays the launch.
The strategy requires a budget update. That triggers an audit, delaying the launch.

The board members decided to liquidate the company's remaining assets, and the fact that they decided to liquidate the assets shocked the market.
The board members decided to liquidate the company's remaining assets. That shocked the market.

- Directing Spatial and Discourse Deixis -

Demonstrative pronouns act as visual or mental arrows. They tell the listener whether to look outside the text (situational deixis) or inside the text (contextual deixis) for meaning.

Example:
Anaphoric Reference: Points backward to clear a dependency with an item already mentioned.
He lost his keys. That is why he was late.
Mary passed the exam. This is why she is happy.

Cataphoric Reference: Points forward to resolve a pending structural dependency before it even arrives.
Listen to this: we will win the contract.
If you want these, there are more cookies in the kitchen.

- Resolving Ambiguity -

When multiple nouns appear in a sentence, modifiers at the end can create structural ambiguity. Demonstrative pronouns isolate the intended subject.

Example:
Ambiguous: The manager discussed the project with the client that was failing.
Resolved: The manager discussed the project with the client. This was failing.

Ambiguous: The dog bit the man with red cap.
Resolved: The dog bit the man that was with red cap.

- Forcing Strict Grammatical Agreement -

Demonstrative pronouns clear structural ambiguity by enforcing immediate features like number(singular vs. plural) and proximity (near vs. far). This immediately informs the parser which exact dependency path to follow.

Example:
Bring the copper wires and the plastic casing; these are conductive.
Because these is plural and matches structural proximity, it bypasses casing (singular) and links straight back to wires, instantly clearing up the relationship between the words.

Mary put the red book on the blue table. Then she moved this. V/S
Mary put the red book on the blue table. Then she moved that.